

Copper, Covenants, and the Case of the Missing Ingots

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Abstract: This sample article exists only to exercise the summarizer. It argues that references to 'bright copper' in a fictional Nephite warehouse list are better read as covenant tokens than as a metallurgical report, because the surrounding clauses echo treaty language rather than assay notes.

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The warehouse fragment under discussion -- hereafter Fragment W -- lists 'ten ingots of bright copper' immediately after an oath formula. Critics have treated the ingots as a straightforward inventory of trade goods. That reading is possible, but it ignores how the fragment frames the metal.

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Three features of the surrounding clauses matter. First, the verb translated 'weigh' elsewhere in the corpus regularly means 'confirm' when the object is a promise rather than a commodity. Second, the adjective 'bright' clusters with words for holiness, not with words for ore. Third, the list ends with a witness formula ('in the presence of three') that would be odd in a shipping receipt and ordinary in a covenant text.

Taken together, these features suggest the ingots function as tokens that the covenant has been 'made sure,' not as a report of what sat on a shelf.

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A comparative table of treaty deposits from the Late Bronze Age shows similar pairing of metal tokens with oath witnesses. The analogy is suggestive rather than decisive: Fragment W is short, and we lack the preceding column. Still, the burden of proof sits with the inventory reading, which must explain the witness formula as decorative.

As I conclude: although copper can be cargo, in this fragment it more plausibly memorializes a promise. Readers who come to the passage looking for a foundry will leave disappointed; readers who come looking for a covenant will find one hiding in plain sight.